Country Profile: Japan

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 6
- Plurality religion: Shintoism, Buddhism
- Official languages: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Japanese

Historical Background

After its defeat in World War II, Japan retained its sovereign status and eventually emerged as a liberal democracy. However, its mandate territories were revoked, with the South Seas Mandate placed under the control of the United States as the Trust Territory of the Pacific Islands in 1947. In 1946, the entire Kuril Islands chain was incorporated into the Soviet Union.[1] Okinawa returned to Japan in 1972.[2] Although generally perceived as a largely homogenous society, Japan's population comprises the Japanese majority as well as Indigenous peoples on outlying islands and migrant groups.

Groups

- **Japanese** are the core group of Japan, with a share of around 98% of the population.[3] They speak the Japanese language[4] and predominantly follow Buddhism, but some also adhere to Shintoism.[5] Both religions are historically associated with the group.[6]
- **Burakumin** are descendants of members of the lowest caste of Edo Japan.[7] While estimates of the size of this group are not uncontested, it appears to be small,

[1] Brown, 2016.
[2] Minority Rights Group, 2019b.
[3] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
[4] Ethnologue, 2024.
[5] Joshua Project, 2025.
[6] Masai and Notehelfer, 2025; Roemer, 2009.
[7] Minority Rights Group, 2019a.

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comprising roughly 1% of the population.[8] The group speaks Japanese and almost entirely adheres to Buddhism.[9]

- **Koreans** arrived in large numbers in Japan in the 1930s and 1940s following the Japanese occupation of Korea and subsequent colonialization attempts.[10] Now they constitute a minority group of less than 0.5% of the population.[11] They speak Korean but also Japanese.[12] While roughly one-fourth of Koreans in Japan adhere to Buddhism, almost one-third of them are Christian, and another third are non-religious.[13]
- **Chinese**, a minority of approximately 0.5% of Japan's population,[14] speak languages of the Chinese macro-language, particularly Mandarin, Min Nan, and Yue.[15] Whereas up to almost half of Chinese adhere to their ancestral religion, Shenism, a small minority follow Buddhism, and more than one-third are non-religious.[16]
- **Ainu** are an Indigenous group primarily residing on the island of Hokkaido and in northern parts of Honshu.[17] Of dwindling size, they are associated with their ancestral Ainu language, which is now nearly extinct and has increasingly been replaced by Japanese.[18] The absolute majority uphold traditional animist beliefs, according to which all things are endowed with a spirit or *kamuy*. A small fraction is Christian.[19] In 1984 separatists demanded a new statute to replace the Aboriginal Law of 1899, marking the start of Ainu political movements for greater self-determination.[20]

[8] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
[9] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
[10] Minority Rights Group, 2019b.
[11] CIA World Fact Book, 2025.
[12] Ethnologue, 2024.
[13] Joshua Project, 2025.
[14] CIA World Fact Book, 2025.
[15] Ethnologue, 2024.
[16] Joshua Project, 2025.
[17] Minority Rights Group, 2019a.
[18] Tahara, 2019; Teeter and Okazaki, 2011.
[19] Joshua Project, 2025; Minority Rights Group, 2019a.
[20] Sambanis, Germann, and Schädel, 2018.

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- **Ryukyuans** form an indigenous group on the Ryukyu archipelago, where they still reside today.[21] They became a visible part of Japan's society, comprising 1% of the state's population,[22] upon the restoration of Japan's authority over the islands in 1972. Ryukyu consists of two territorial units: the Satsunan Islands and Okinawa Prefecture. Although members of this group traditionally spoke Miyako, Central Okinawan, and Yaeyama, most have shifted increasingly to Japanese since the 1990s.[23] Most Ryukyuans are non-religious, while around one-fourth adhere to Shintoism and the rest to Buddhism.[24] In the past, a sizable share of the group members also followed Taoist beliefs. The group has entertained a self-determination movement since 1972, the year Okiwana was transferred back to Japan.[25]

State Profile

Official Language

The Constitution of Japan does not mention any official language. Nonetheless, Japanese is universally used in legislation, government administration, and judicial proceedings. All national laws and official documents are written exclusively in Japanese, and public education is conducted in Japanese as the standard language of instruction.

Official Religion

Article 20 of the 1946 Constitution affirms the principle of separation of church and state, declaring that there shall be no state religion. It states: "No religious organization shall receive any privileges from the State, nor exercise any political authority."[26]

Education Policies

Japan relies on a state-funded public education system. The system comprises mandatory primary and secondary schools, spanning 6 years and 3 years respectively, and voluntary secondary schools. Although secondary education is neither mandatory

[21] Minority Rights Group, 2019b.
[22] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.
[23] Heinrich and Ishihara, 2017.
[24] Joshua Project, 2025.
[25] Sambanis, Germann, and Schädel, 2018.
[26] Constitution of Japan, 1946.

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nor free, the clear majority of students enter these institutions, which are divided into vocational and university entrance streams.[27]

Before the 1947 Fundamental Law of Education, schooling in Japan was already compulsory and allowed for both public and **private** options, but the system was monolingual, elitist, and ideologically imperial. While foreign-language schools like Chinese- and Korean-medium institutions were previously unrecognized and excluded from university pathways, in 2003 the government granted official recognition to selected international private schools.[28]

Language Education Policies

The public education system relies on **Japanese** as the language of instruction in primary and secondary schools.[29] This is also the case in minority-populated areas such as Okinawa where Japanese is the language of instruction, and **Okinawan** is not taught.[30] In 1991, **Korean** and **Chinese** were introduced as optional foreign language classes in secondary schools.[31]

Religious Education Policies

While Shintō moral teaching was mandatory in schools since the Meiji Restoration and until the Shintō directive in 1945, public schools in Japan have not imparted instruction in any religion or sectarian denomination between 1945 and 2020.[32] In Japan, private schools are permitted to include religious education in their curricula if they are affiliated with a particular faith, as outlined in Article 50(2) and Article 79 of the School Education Law. As of recent data, approximately 25% of private secondary schools have religious affiliations, including institutions connected to Roman Catholicism, Protestantism, Buddhism, Shinto, and newer religious movements.[33]

[27] Scholaro, n.d.
[28] Beauchamp and Rubinger, 2017.
[29] L'Aménagement linguistique dans le monde, 2023.
[30] Heinrich, Miyara, and Shimoji, 2015.
[31] Hou, 2016.
[32] State Shintō, 2025; The Religion and State Project, 2023.
[33] Mukhsen, 2020.

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Bans and Restrictions

While bans on the use of Korean were in place before 1945,[34] there were no bans or restrictions on the use of languages or the exercise of religion between 1945 and 2020.

Constitutions and Laws

Two constitutions have been in force in Japan between 1945 and 2020. The Meiji Constitution was adopted in 1889. This was replaced by a new constitution, written mainly by American officials during the occupation of Japan at the end of World War II, in 1946.

Both constitutions make only an ambiguous reference to Japanese subjects, in the 1889 Constitution, or the Japanese people, in the 1946 Constitution.[35] The former constitution did not establish a secular state, and its provisions on religion referred to "Japanese subjects," granting them freedom of religious belief.[36] This is remedied by the 1946 constitution, which sets out the separation between church and state and provides for universal freedom of religion, asserting that "Freedom of religion is guaranteed to all."[37] Neither constitution recognizes an official language.

Citizenship Laws

Access to Japanese citizenship was first governed by the 1899 law and then by the 1950 Nationality Law. Following Japan's self-perception as mono-ethnic, the legal framework does not differentiate based on ethnic identity.[38] In principle, the Nationality Law follows the principle of *ius sanguinis*. As such, there is no birthright citizenship for children born to foreign parents.[39] Koreans and Taiwanese were deprived of Japanese citizenship when Japanese control over Korean and Taiwanese territories was lost in 1947, but their descendants can apply for naturalization under the 1950 Nationality Law.

[34] Cf. e.g., Halliday, 1981.
[35] Constitution of 1889, Art. 18, Ch. II; Constitution of 1946, Preamble.
[36] Constitution of 1889, Art. 28, Ch. II.
[37] Constitution of 1946, Arts. 20 and 89.
[38] Kashiwazaki, 1998.
[39] Kondo, 2016.

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National Anthem(s)

One national anthem was in use between 1945 and 2020. With lyrics from the 10th century, and *de facto* in use as an anthem since the 19th century, "Kimigayo" (君が代) was officially adopted as the anthem of Japan in 1999.[40] The anthem extols the Emperors as divine rulers and gods in Shintoism and, as such, includes extensive political, ideological, and religious references.

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[40] Nationalanthems.info, 2024.

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